

Teaching Statement

The famous German philosopher Karl Theodor Jaspers said, “The essence of education means that one tree shakes another tree, one cloud pushes another cloud, and one soul awakens another soul.” Before I came to the United States for college, I had my education in China, and the emphasis of only scores and right answers gives me the impression of educating a machine. I think a good and authentic education is a kind of education of a whole person that inspires and awakens the soul instead of just the conveying of knowledge. I find teaching and mentoring students incredible rewarding and enjoying for me as this is a process of awakening another soul. My goals of teaching are to help students enjoying learning Economics, provide students the learning experience that they could relate to real life, and teach with enthusiasm and wholeheartedly.

To achieve those goals and awaken another soul, I use backward design to craft the curriculum and use scaffolding approach to conduct lectures and create assignments. I think this approach is important for education because if a course is designed such that students are in the zone of proximal development (ZPD), then they can achieve the learning goals with support and guidance. If the course is too easy, then students do not get much from the course and if the course is too hard, then students may find the class discouraging. To help students to achieve ZPD, for example, I would let students to complete problems with me first, and then in the second half of the lecture work on the problem sets on their own. Designing a class with the right balance and providing students with a scaffolding approach can help students get the most of a course.

To help students understand economics and apply it into their daily life, I like to introduce concepts with real life examples, and then walk them through practice problems step by step so that they can grasp the concept better. I think giving real life and general examples are important for students from different backgrounds to understand material. For instance, I would provide real life examples like Costco and Amazon Prime memberships when I was explaining the price strategy of two-part tariffs. During the class, I would ask students questions of what other examples they could think of in their daily life and some students would give the answer such as a video game system. I think providing real life examples and encouraging students to come up with their own examples allow students to understand the concepts better.

I think teaching another soul with enthusiasm inspires students to have the intrinsic motivation to learn Economics because they find it interesting. It is fulfilling to know that my students start to get interested in Economics after taking my class. One of the comments that I received from my students is that “I have always disliked studying Economics, but this summer class made it easy for me to understand and follow along. I no longer dislike economics and I feel that I am more confident about my knowledge on this topic.” If my students start to like Economics because of taking my class, that is a great honor for me.

I believe a great instructor inspires and encourages students to do their best and educate students as a whole person. Furthermore, I think building a supporting connection with the students are also important and rewarding. Through adopting backward design, a scaffolding approach, real-life examples, and learner-centered teaching, I am confident that I can achieve my teaching goals of teaching another soul engagingly, effectively, and passionately.